

HORS D'OEUVRES | **DILIP BOBB**

The New Power Elite



Shorn of the blinkered politics and crass behaviour of some of our elected representatives, the contentious Women's Bill has resurrected a tricky contemporary debate: affirmative action versus meritocracy. The cover story in this issue is on the Power Elite. Historian Charles Wright Mills coined the phrase, and the title of his book, to describe a small group of people who control a disproportionate amount of wealth, privilege and access to decision-making. He wrote that in 1956 when it was certainly true of America and its so-called Protestant Establishment but is no longer extant thanks to affirmative action. India, 63 years ago, had a similar power elite, a limited group of people with advanced education or advanced minds, often both. Today, it's a vastly different playing field but one class of meritocracy has quietly replaced another.

It's reflected in the rise of what I call the Talent Elite. They are visible in every field of human endeavour, and include a large number of women. I remember in the mid-70s fresh out of college, my first job interview took place in the plush environs of an elite club in Calcutta over a five-course meal. There were basically two issues at stake: my father was a member of the same club as the managing director interviewing me and I had passed out of the 'right' school and college. Then, it was all that mattered. In 2010, maybe the IIT's and IIM's have some of that same aura but today's leaders are no longer restricted to alumni from a handful of public schools in the hills of north India. Being smart, ambitious and an innovative thinker is what counts these days, regardless of background and educational institution.

Some would argue that the promise of meritocracy has not been fulfilled, and certainly in India we have still not reached a stage where sections of society, including women, can progress without affirmative action. Nor has meritocracy enhanced key institutions. One section of the High & Mighty list includes The Advisers, tech-

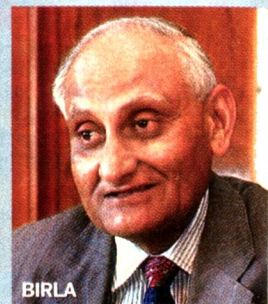
nocrats and economists meant to bring collective wisdom and a private sector approach to governance. Yet, the Government is not viewed as being more efficient or innovative in its actions. However, there's another side to the talent coin. The level of transparency in today's society makes it impossible to hide mediocrity or suppress talent. The level playing field is increasingly in evidence but what it has also produced is the talent elite who dominate the collective mindspace and Page 3 columns. Indeed, a majority of the names on our High & Mighty list have remained the same since we started the editorial exercise. In that sense, they are not much different from the original Power Elite, a handful of people with extraordinary ability but also the collective clout to influence decision-making through their simultaneous access to both state and corporate power.



SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Industrialist **Ganga Prasad Birla**, 87. He was the head of the Rs 5,000-crore G.P.-C.K. Birla Group of companies which owns Hindustan Motors, Orient Fans, Orient Papers and Hyderabad Industries.



WON: By world champion **Manavjit Singh Sandhu**, the trap gold at the Shotgun World Cup in Mexico. This is the four-time Asian champion's first gold in a world cup event.

DIED: **Saraswati Dalmia**, poet, writer and a scholar of Sanskrit and Hindi who had authored *Nirajana*. She was the widow of industrialist Rama-krishna Dalmia.

DIED: **Pravinchandra V. Gandhi**, 87, former chairman of Press Trust of India and ex-chairman emeritus of the Saurashtra Trust that publishes the Janmabhoomi group of newspapers and magazines.

